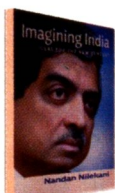


Lessons on Nation Building

Nilekani's book of ideas and idealism tells the story of a transformation and sells hope



IMAGINING INDIA:
IDEAS FOR THE
NEW CENTURY
by NANDAN NILEKANI
Allen Lane
Price: Rs 699
Pages: 531

| By S. Prasannarajan |

Five hundred years after Christopher Columbus reported to King Ferdinand and Queen Isabella of Spain that the world was indeed round, an American columnist experienced an epiphany on the road to Bangalore. Earlier, he was sitting on a couch outside Nandan Nilekani's office at Infosys Technologies Limited on the outskirts of the city, listening to the company's CEO, "one of the most thoughtful and respected captains of Indian industry." Then Nilekani said those magic words that would lead to the title of the next bestseller by Thomas L. Friedman of the *New York Times*, an op-ed pundit with a rock star aura whose 800 words twice a week are mandatory reading for globalisation junkies. "Tom," said Nilekani, "the playing field is being levelled." Friedman would write in his book, *The World is Flat*: "He meant that countries like India are now able to compete for global knowledge work as never before—and that India had better get ready for this." As the columnist drove back to the city that evening, he "kept chewing on that phrase: The playing field is being levelled. What Nandan is saying, I thought, is that the playing field is being flattened... Flattened? Flattened? My God, he's telling me the world is flat!"

In the flat world, ideas travel fast, and in the wake of Mumbai, we know that those ideas are not necessarily the ones that unite. Let's not spoil the party, though. Let's stick to ideas that are fed into the computers in Bangalore, one of the most sought after shrines in the flat world; ideas that power the engines of globalisation. An India where Bangalore is possible and Infosys is a brand that defies frontiers is not only an indispensable item in the conference rooms of Davos. This

India is a provocation too, for beyond the much rhapsodised marketplaces, beyond the audacity of the Indian entrepreneurship, there is an India that is damned, irredeemable—after *The White Tiger*, which reduces the distance between Bangalore and Bihar, it's even worth a Booker. Nilekani, in his own words "an accidental entrepreneur" but in practice one of India's most visible travellers in the flat world, may embody the Corporate India of Yes-We-Can. *Imagining India*, though, is not a cheerleader's manifesto. It is a sprawling book of ideas and idealism.

Part corporate memoir, part history, part sociology, part political punditry, part economic lecture, part pep talk, this book anatomises India's transformation and celebrates hope. The narrative draws its legitimacy from the biography of its author, and the book's cover illustrates it without any understatement. As a co-founder of Infosys, Nilekani knows a few things about the power of romance. In the "awakened country", Nilekani argues, there should be a fine balance between opportunity and individual romance.

He believes "the only way to push changes through and safeguard our economic future is to create a safety net of ideas. It is imperative to ensure that our ideas transcend political agendas and are endorsed and demanded by a large number of people."

Drawing from his experience as a dreamer, traveller, observer, administrator and a prominent character in the script of India Rising, he offers more than hope and optimism. He guides us through the politics of division and the economics of development, the treacherous alleys of caste and the areas of stagnation, and "rediscovers" an India that is "young, impatient, vital, awake..." Nilekani is no longer a title-providing character in someone else's book on globalisation; with *Imagining India*, he has become the biographer of a country that is caught between the ideas of change and the dead certainties of politics.

